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PREPARING TO SAY FAREWELL

Dignitaries arrive to pay their respects to Pope Francis on Friday in Vatican City. Francis, who died on Monday, lay in state for a final day ahead of Saturday’s funeral in St. Peter’s Square. **WORLD, A4**

California sees sharp rise in valley fever cases in first 3 months of 2025

BY SUSANNE RUST

California is heading toward another record year for cases of valley fever, the disease caused by fungal spores linked to cycles of drought and precipitation. There were 3,123 reported cases of valley fever in the first three months of the year, according to state health officials — roughly double the 10-year average for the first-quarter time period. Cases ranged from a low of 801 in 2016 to 3,011 last year. Most people who are infected with the fungus won’t



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

A TRACTOR plows a field in Paso Robles, Calif. Valley fever, caused by a fungal infection that spreads through dust, has increased in frequency in the state.

experience symptoms, and their bodies will fight off the infection naturally. Those who do suffer symptoms are often hard-pressed to recognize them, as they resemble the onset of COVID or the flu, further complicating efforts to address the disease. The disease is caused by inhaling spores of *Coccidioides*, a fungal pathogen that thrives in the drier and dustier regions of the state. The fungus is released when the dry soil where it grows is disturbed. “We actually had sort of seen this coming, just based [See Valley fever, A8]

FBI arrests judge accused of helping migrant evade ICE

The county jurist in Milwaukee allegedly obstructed agents at her courthouse.

BY JENNY JARVIE AND HANNAH FRY

The Trump administration significantly ramped up its clash over immigration with officials at the state and local level on Friday after FBI agents arrested a county judge in Milwaukee, accusing her of obstructing an immigration arrest. “Just NOW, the FBI arrested Judge Hannah Dugan out of Milwaukee, Wisconsin on charges of obstruction — after evidence of Judge Dugan obstructing an immigration arrest operation last week,” FBI Director Kash Patel posted Friday morning on the social media site known as X. “We believe Judge Dugan intentionally misdirected federal agents away from the subject to be arrested in her courthouse, Eduardo [Flores-Ruiz], allowing the subject — an illegal alien — to evade arrest,” Patel added. “Thankfully, our agents chased down the perp on foot and he’s been in custody since, but the Judge’s obstruction created increased danger to the public.” Brady McCarron, deputy chief of public affairs for the U.S. Marshals Service, confirmed that Dugan, a Milwaukee County circuit judge, was arrested by the FBI at 8:30 a.m. Friday. Dugan was charged with “obstruction or impeding a proceeding before a department or agency of the United States” and “concealing an individual to prevent his discovery and arrest,” according to a criminal complaint

filed in U.S. District Court for the Eastern District of Wisconsin. An FBI special agent assigned to the Milwaukee Field Office said in an affidavit that Flores-Ruiz was charged on March 18 in Milwaukee with battery, domestic abuse and infliction of physical pain or injury. Agents from the U.S. Department of Homeland Security and Immigration and Customs Enforcement, Enforcement and Removal Operations subsequently identified Flores-Ruiz, a Mexican citizen, as “not lawfully in the United States” and obtained a warrant for his arrest. “This criminal illegal alien has a laundry list of violent criminal charges including strangulation and suffocation, battery, and domestic abuse,” Tricia McLaughlin, a spokesperson for the Department of Homeland Security, said in a statement, noting that Flores-Ruiz illegally entered the U.S. twice. When ICE agents came to Dugan’s courthouse April 18 to arrest Flores-Ruiz after his criminal court appearance, the affidavit said, Dugan became “visibly angry” and commented that the situation was “absurd.” According to the affidavit, Dugan approached a deportation officer with a “confrontational, angry demeanor.” After asking officers from the arrest team whether they had a judicial warrant and demanding that they speak with the chief judge, Dugan then escorted Flores-Ruiz and his counsel out of the courtroom through a back “jury door,” which leads to a non-public area of the courthouse. Flores-Ruiz was chased [See Judge, A6]

Local film industry has hopes pinned on two bills

Legislation to boost film, TV tax incentive program clears its first hurdles in Sacramento.

BY SAMANTHA MASUNAGA

It’s showtime for Hollywood at the California Capitol. The state’s entertainment industry has spent months begging for help from Sacramento to stem the decline of film and TV production and save thousands of jobs. This week, after months of speeches and promises from public officials, two bills meant to boost the beleaguered business cleared their first legislative hurdles. The bills are intended to make California’s film and TV production incentive more competitive with other states and countries by increasing the tax credit up to 35% of qualified expenditures and expanding the types of productions that would be eligible. It’s a potential lifeline for the entertainment industry, which has been battered in recent years by production slowdowns wrought by the [See Hollywood, A10]

State bar admits to developing exam questions with AI

Revelation raises fresh shock after February’s much-maligned test.

BY JENNY JARVIE

Nearly two months after hundreds of prospective California lawyers complained that their bar exams

were plagued with technical problems and irregularities, the state’s legal licensing body has caused fresh outrage by admitting that some multiple-choice questions were developed with the aid of artificial intelligence. The State Bar of California said in a news release Monday that it will ask the California Supreme Court to

adjust test scores for those who took its February bar exam. But it declined to acknowledge significant problems with its multiple-choice questions — even as it revealed that a subset of questions were recycled from a first-year law student exam, while others were developed with the assistance

of AI by ACS Ventures, the state bar’s independent psychometrician. “The debacle that was the February 2025 bar exam is worse than we imagined,” said Mary Basic, assistant dean of academic skills at UC Irvine Law School. “I’m almost speechless. Having the questions drafted by non-lawyers using artificial

intelligence is just unbelievable.” After completing the exam, Basic said, some test takers complained that some of the questions felt as if they were written by AI. “I defended the bar,” Basic said. “No way! They wouldn’t do that!” Using AI-developed [See Bar exam, A8]



JASON ARMOND Los Angeles Times

A PAIR of cars that were destroyed in the Eaton fire sit on a street in Altadena. Dave Stone, a resident of nearby Pasadena, has been documenting the vehicles that were lost or left behind in the blaze and their owners on his Instagram page.

Altadena car buffs are on the road to healing

BY MARAH EAKIN

It’s 8 a.m. on a Saturday and cars are starting to roll into the parking lot next to Unincorporated Coffee Roasters in Altadena. There’s a green 1979 Mercedes 300SD Turbo Diesel in the corner, sitting next to a rust-orange vintage Mustang. Across from it, a shiny blue Volkswagen Mk4 R32 takes the slot next to a long, powder blue lowrider and a beautifully pinstriped 1948 Chevrolet truck, which rolled in blaring its siren-like horn. To get to the Altadena

Cars & Coffee meetup, a Saturday hangout for car enthusiasts, attendees had to traverse some portion of Altadena, passing homes and businesses reduced to rubble by the Eaton fire. Tyreke and Traivon Jackson passed their lot at Lincoln Avenue and Figueroa Street, where they’d worked on cars for as long as they could remember. Passersby wouldn’t have known what was on the lot before the fire, but now, with fences and foliage destroyed, the damage is clear. “We lost a ’64 Impala convertible, a ’79 Monte Carlo, two ’87 Cutlasses and an ’83 [See Altadena, A12]

New challenge to deportations

Trump’s tactic amounts to punishment and should require a trial, expert says. **NATION, A5**

Gaza food stocks are out, U.N. says

Amid blockade, aid agency said it sent its last supplies to charity kitchens. **WORLD, A3**

Weighing a trans legal strategy

Maine has lost federal funding over rules that California shares. **CALIFORNIA, B1**

Weather

Cool and wet. L.A. Basin: 62/50. **B8**
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